

Curry Powder Masala (Special Dhaniya Podi)

A deeply aromatic South Indian-style coriander-based curry powder that works beautifully for kuzhambu, curries, vegetable stir-fries, gravies, and dry masalas. This version balances warmth, spice, nuttiness, and earthy complexity while remaining versatile for everyday cooking.

Ingredients

- 2 cups coriander seeds
- 6 dried red chilies (adjust to heat preference)
- 1 tbsp whole black pepper
- 1 tbsp cumin seeds
- 1 tbsp fennel seeds (saunf)
- 1/2 tsp fenugreek seeds
- 1-inch cinnamon stick
- 4 cloves
- 1 bay leaf
- 3 green cardamom pods
- 1 small star anise
- 1 small piece kalpasi (stone flower)
- 10 cashew nuts
- 1 cup loosely packed curry leaves
- Optional: 1 tsp turmeric powder

Dry Roasting Method

- Use a heavy-bottomed kadai or skillet on low to medium heat.
- Dry roast coriander seeds first for 4–5 minutes until aromatic and lightly deeper in color.
- Remove and cool.
- Roast red chilies carefully for 1–2 minutes without burning.
- Roast pepper, cumin, fennel, and fenugreek separately for about 1 minute each.
- Lightly roast cinnamon, cloves, bay leaf, cardamom, star anise, and kalpasi until fragrant.
- Roast cashews until lightly golden.
- Finally roast curry leaves until completely dry and crisp.

- Cool all ingredients completely before grinding.

Grinding Instructions

- Grind all roasted ingredients together into a fine or slightly coarse powder based on preference.
- Add turmeric powder after grinding if using.
- Allow powder to cool fully before storing.

Storage Tips

- Store in airtight glass jars.
- Keep away from moisture.
- Best flavor within 2–3 months.
- Can refrigerate for longer freshness.
- Use a dry spoon always.

Flavor Profile Notes

- Coriander seeds create the main body and earthy sweetness.
- Fenugreek gives slight bitterness and curry depth.
- Kalpasi adds restaurant-style aroma.
- Cashews provide subtle richness and smoothness.
- Curry leaves add classic South Indian flavor.

Variations

- Chettinad Style: increase pepper and fennel; add more kalpasi.
- Mild Version: reduce red chilies and pepper.
- Spicy Version: add Kashmiri and Guntur chilies combination.
- Coconut Version: add dry roasted desiccated coconut (shorter shelf life).
- Low-Carb Rich Version: add extra curry leaves and pepper for stronger flavor without carbs.
- Sambar-Style Version: add roasted toor dal and chana dal.

Usage Suggestions

- Use in kuzhambu and gravies.
- Mix into poriyal or vegetable stir-fries.

- Add to curries, kootu, and masala rice.
- Can be sprinkled over roasted vegetables.
- Works well in marinades for paneer or tofu.

Approximate Nutrition (Per Tablespoon)

- Calories: ~28–35
- Net Carbs: ~2–3g
- Protein: ~1g
- Fat: ~1–2g
- High in antioxidants and aromatic oils.

Important Tips

- Always roast on low-medium heat to avoid bitterness.
- Do not grind while ingredients are hot.
- Over-roasting fenugreek can make the masala bitter.
- Curry leaves must become fully crisp before grinding.
- For smoother texture use a spice grinder in batches.